

ADA / WCAG 2.1 Accessibility Audit

Colorado Courts E-Filing — Security Question and Answer Page

Page	Colorado Courts E-Filing — Security Question and Answer
URL	https://www.jbits.courts.state.co.us/efiling/web/forgotPasswordAnswer.htm
Standard	Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.1, Level AA
Audit Date	May 5, 2026
Method	Code- and structure-level review of public HTML; not a substitute for automated scanning, screen-reader testing, or live keyboard testing.

Summary

The page is relatively simple in structure but has a number of accessibility deficiencies spanning form labeling, error handling, ARIA usage, heading structure, color contrast, and dialog implementation. Several issues are likely to create barriers for screen-reader users and keyboard-only users, and the page is also currently returning a generic system error to users arriving from the preceding step in the password-recovery flow. The most impactful fixes to prioritize are the error-handling issues (Issues 3 and 4) and the required-field semantics (Issues 1 and 2), as these directly impact users who rely on screen readers for form interaction — the primary use case of this page.

Issues Found

1. Required Field Asterisk Not Hidden from Assistive Technology

WCAG 1.3.1 · Fail

The asterisk (*) in the label `*Answer:` is rendered via a `<span class="text-danger">` element with no `aria-hidden="true"`. Screen readers will announce “asterisk Answer” when focusing the field, which is poor UX. The asterisk is a visual-only convention and should be hidden from assistive technology, with the required nature communicated programmatically instead (see Issue 2).

Fix. Add `aria-hidden="true"` to the asterisk span. Add `aria-required="true"` or the HTML `required` attribute to the input.

2. Required Input Missing `required` / `aria-required`

WCAG 1.3.1, 3.3.2 · Fail

The Answer field has no `required` attribute and no `aria-required="true"`. Screen-reader users have no programmatic way to know the field is mandatory.

Fix. Add `required` (or `aria-required="true"`) to `<input id="answer">`.

3. Error Message Not Programmatically Associated with Input

WCAG 1.3.1, 3.3.1 · Fail

The error message “Answer to security question is incorrect.” is displayed on screen but is not linked to the input field via `aria-describedby`. Screen-reader users navigating directly to the input will not hear the error. Additionally, the input lacks `aria-invalid="true"` when in the error state.

Fix. Give the error element a unique id (e.g. `id="answer-error"`), add `aria-describedby="answer-error"` to the input, and set `aria-invalid="true"` on the input when the error state is active.

4. Error Message Has No Live Region / `role="alert"`

WCAG 4.1.3 · Fail

The error message is injected into the DOM after a failed submission, but the container element (the `<ul>`) has no `aria-live="assertive"` or `role="alert"`. Screen-reader users who submit the form will not automatically hear the error announcement.

Fix. Add `role="alert"` (or `aria-live="assertive"`) to the error-message container so that it is announced dynamically when it appears.

5. Heading Hierarchy is Incorrect — No H1 on Page

WCAG 1.3.1 · Fail

The page's primary heading “Security Question and Answer” is marked as `<h3>`, and there is no `<h1>` or `<h2>` anywhere on the page. The hidden modal dialogs in the DOM also introduce out-of-order headings (`<h4>` elements that appear before the main `<h3>` in DOM order). This disrupts navigation for screen-reader users who use heading keys to scan page structure.

Fix. The main page heading should be `<h1>`. Modal dialog headings should be subordinate to the page structure and ideally not participate in the main document outline at all (place them inside `<dialog>` elements or containers with `aria-modal="true"`).

6. All Modal Dialogs Missing `aria-modal="true"`

WCAG 4.1.2 · Fail

Six `div[role="dialog"]` elements (`alertDialogBox`, `confirmDialogBox`, `infoDialogBox`, `noItemsDialogBox`, `compatibilityCheckDialog`, `customerSupportDialog`) are missing `aria-modal="true"`. Without this, screen readers using virtual or browse mode may read content behind the open dialog, which can be very confusing.

Fix. Add `aria-modal="true"` to each `div[role="dialog"]`. Additionally, ensure focus is trapped inside open dialogs and returned to the triggering element on close.

7. Navigation Landmark Missing `aria-label`

WCAG 2.4.6 · Fail

The `<nav>` element has no `aria-label` attribute. If there were multiple navigation regions on the page, screen-reader users would not be able to distinguish them. Even with a single `nav`, an `aria-label` (e.g. `aria-label="Main navigation"`) is best practice.

Fix. Add `aria-label="Main navigation"` (or similar) to the `<nav>` element.

8. Submit Button Color Contrast — Borderline

WCAG 1.4.3 · Needs Review

The Submit button uses black text (`rgb(0, 0, 0)`) on a yellow background (`#FFC107`). The contrast ratio is approximately 10.7:1, which passes. However, the Cancel button uses black text on a mid-gray background (`rgb(108, 117, 125)` / Bootstrap `btn-secondary`). Black on that gray yields approximately **4.0:1**, which is below the 4.5:1 AA threshold for normal text under 18px (or 14px bold). The Cancel button text appears to be 14px non-bold, putting it just **below** the AA threshold.

Fix. Verify the Cancel button contrast ratio precisely. If it fails, darken the text or lighten or change the background to achieve at least 4.5:1.

9. Label Text Includes Asterisk in Accessible Name

WCAG 2.5.3 · Fail

Because the asterisk `<span>` is inside the `<label>` and not `aria-hidden`, the computed accessible name of the input becomes “* Answer:” — the asterisk is literally read as part of the label by screen readers. This makes voice-control commands like “Click Answer” less predictable.

Fix. Apply `aria-hidden="true"` to the asterisk span (as noted in Issue 1), making the accessible name cleanly “Answer:”.

10. Footer Links Using javascript: Pseudo-Protocol

WCAG 2.1.1, 4.1.2 · Fail

Two footer links use `href="javascript:runCompatibilityCheckPopup()"` and `href="javascript:custSupportPopup()"`. These are not real `<button>` elements and do not behave consistently across all assistive-technology and browser combinations. Links are expected to navigate; actions should use `<button>` elements.

Fix. Replace both with `<button>` elements styled as links. As an interim measure, `href="#"` with an `onclick` handler that calls `preventDefault()` plus `role="button"` is acceptable, but real `<button>` elements are preferred.

11. Spelling Typo in Dialog Heading

WCAG Content Quality · Minor

The Customer Support dialog contains the heading “**LAW FIRMS, PRIVATE AGENCIES, AND GOVERNMENT AGENCIES**” — “GOVERNMENT” is misspelled (missing an ‘N’). While not a WCAG violation per se, this appears in content read by screen readers and should be corrected.

Fix. Change to “GOVERNMENT AGENCIES.”

12. Page Title Is Not Descriptive Enough

WCAG 2.4.2 · Minor / Best Practice

The page `<title>` is simply “Colorado Courts E-Filing” — the same as every other page in the application. It does not describe the current task (“Security Question and Answer”). Screen-reader users and those with multiple tabs open cannot distinguish pages by title.

Fix. Use a unique, descriptive title such as “Security Question and Answer — Colorado Courts E-Filing.”

13. Skip Link Is Present (Pass)

WCAG 2.4.1 · Pass

The skip link ("Skip to main content") is visually hidden using CSS clipping and targets #mainContent, which correctly corresponds to the <main id="mainContent"> element. This is an acceptable pattern and passes.

14. Image Alt Text Is Adequate (Pass)

WCAG 1.1.1 · Pass

The Colorado Courts Seal image has alt="Colorado Courts Seal", which is appropriate.

15. lang Attribute Is Present (Pass)

WCAG 3.1.1 · Pass

The <html> element has lang="en", which is correct.

Priority Summary

Issues are listed in approximate order of user impact rather than by issue number. Severity reflects likely barrier to a screen-reader or keyboard-only user completing the password-recovery task.

#	Issue	WCAG Criterion	Severity
4	Error message has no live region / role="alert"	4.1.3	Critical
3	Error not linked to input via aria-describedby / aria-invalid	1.3.1, 3.3.1	High
2	Required field missing required / aria-required	1.3.1, 3.3.2	High
1	Asterisk not aria-hidden; pollutes accessible name	1.3.1	High
5	No H1; broken heading hierarchy	1.3.1	High
6	All dialogs missing aria-modal="true"	4.1.2	High
10	javascript: pseudo-links should be buttons	2.1.1, 4.1.2	Medium
8	Cancel button color contrast may fail AA	1.4.3	Medium
7	Navigation landmark missing aria-label	2.4.6	Low
12	Non-unique page title	2.4.2	Low
9	Label includes asterisk in accessible name	2.5.3	Low
11	"GOVERNMENT" typo in dialog heading	Content	Minor
13	Skip link present and functional	2.4.1	Pass
14	Image alt text adequate on Colorado Courts Seal	1.1.1	Pass
15	lang attribute present on	3.1.1	Pass

Recommended Remediation Order

1. Resolve the generic system error currently returned by forgotPasswordAnswer.htm; users routed to this page from the preceding step cannot complete recovery at all.
2. Fix Issues 3 and 4 (error programmatic association and live-region announcement) so screen-reader users are notified when a security-question answer is rejected.
3. Fix Issues 1, 2, and 9 (required-field semantics and accessible name) so the field communicates its required state and reads cleanly.
4. Fix Issue 5 (heading hierarchy) and Issue 6 (modal aria-modal) so structural navigation works.
5. Address Issues 7, 8, 10, 11, and 12 in routine maintenance.
6. **Strategic recommendation, separate from per-issue remediation:** evaluate replacing knowledge-based recovery (security questions) with an email-delivered one-time link or code. Knowledge-based authentication is explicitly discouraged by NIST SP 800-63B and is the pattern WCAG 2.2 Success Criterion 3.3.8 (Accessible Authentication) was added to address. This single change would

eliminate the cognitive-function barrier that several of the issues above exist to mitigate.

Scope and Limitations

This audit is based on a structural review of the page's public HTML and is not a substitute for a full accessibility evaluation. A complete audit would additionally include automated testing (axe-core, WAVE, Lighthouse), manual screen-reader testing across NVDA, JAWS, and VoiceOver, keyboard-only navigation testing, color-contrast measurement on the rendered DOM at the exact rendered pixel sizes, and testing of the page in the failure state (with the actual error message rendered). This document does not constitute legal advice regarding compliance with the Americans with Disabilities Act, Colorado House Bill 21-1110, Section 508 of the Rehabilitation Act, or any other statute or regulation. It is a technical conformance review against WCAG 2.1 Level AA criteria intended to support a remediation conversation with the operator of the page.